

opment plank. The BJP in Gujarat has also invalidated the belief that elections can be won only by appealing to people's caste and community sentiments. Furthermore, unlike in CPI(M)-ruled West Bengal, the BJP in Gujarat has demonstrated that a renewed mandate can be won without all recourse to electoral malpractices.

I consider the outcome of the Gujarat polls significant for another reason. It showed how a leader with integrity, courage and competence could count on people's support to beat back a personalised campaign of vilification. I cannot think of any other leader in Indian politics in the past sixty years who was as viciously, consistently and persistently maligned, both nationally and internationally, as Modi had been since 2002. Sonia Gandhi even went to the extent of calling him *maut ka saudagar* (merchant of death). I am happy that the people of Gujarat have given a fitting reply to the practitioners of this kind of toxic politics.

State Assembly elections are quite frequent in our country, but rarely does the people's verdict in a particular state become a turning point in national politics. I have no doubt that my party's spectacular victory in Gujarat would indeed become a turning point because it signals BJP's resurgence as the front-runner in the next parliamentary elections.

## ■ NO REGRETS

*When you have decided what you believe, what you feel must be done, have the courage to stand alone and be counted.* —Eleanor Roosevelt

**W**hen I first came to know, while I was still in Karachi, about the storm generated by my visit to Jinnah's mausoleum and my remarks about him, I asked my staff to send the complete text of Jinnah's speech in the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan, which projected the vision of a secular state, to my party colleagues in Delhi. As a matter of fact, it was not for the first time on a public platform that I had referred to Jinnah's vision of a secular Pakistan. On 28 February 2004, the India First Foundation, established by my colleague Dinanath Mishra had invited me to release one of its publications, *Dialogue With Pakistan* by S.G. Kashikar. Mishra, a prominent Hindi journalist, has a long and close association with the RSS leadership. The function held at my residence was attended by many senior personalities from the party and Sangh Parivar organisations, and well covered by the media. Indeed, I had begun my rather comprehensive speech on the occasion by mentioning my last meeting with Swami Ranganathananda in Kolkata few months earlier and our discussion about Jinnah's address to the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan. I had extensively quoted from his speech while presenting my own thoughts on secularism and normalisation of Indo-Pak relations. Therefore, at least to many of my colleagues in my political and ideological fraternity, the specific context in which I had made an appreciative reference to Jinnah could not have been unfamiliar.

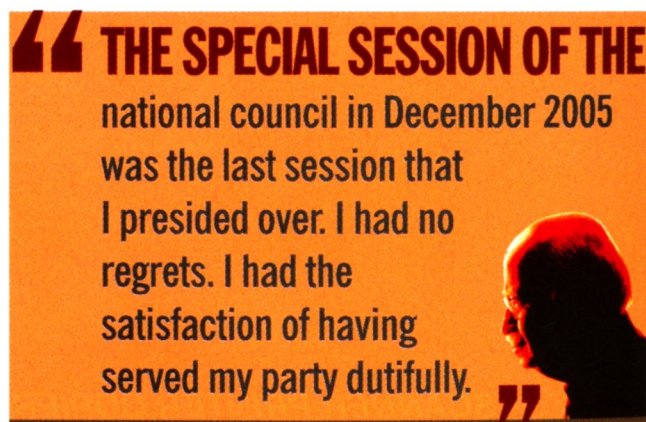
But what pained me is that some people thought that I had committed a serious ideological heresy even before acquainting themselves with full facts and background infor-

mation. Therefore, even before I emplaned the Pakistan International Airlines flight back to Delhi on the morning of 6 June, I had decided, with an anguish-filled heart, to resign from my position as the president of the BJP.

I submitted my resignation on 7 June. It would not be an exaggeration to say that I was upset. However, my resignation was not accepted by the BJP's Parliamentary Board and central office-bearers, who, in a meeting on 8 June, unanimously adopted a resolution urging me to continue leading the party, "which he has so ably led in the past".

During the same period, I also received anguished messages from state-level colleagues and *karyakartas* from all over the country, all appealing that I withdraw my resignation. I did so, bowing to the collective wish of my colleagues and also in the best interest of the party. Unfortunately, this did not put an end to the turbulence. One day, in the middle of 2005, I was told that I should step down from presidentship of the BJP by the year-end after the conclusion of the party's ongoing silver jubilee commemoration.

All this was profoundly agonising for me. I was in a dilemma. What should I do? How should I respond to this situation? Never in my political life was I enamoured by any post or the power that supposedly came with it. I had agreed to assume the organisational responsibility only because of



the insistence of my colleagues.

The BJP held a crucial meeting of its national executive in Chennai in 18-19 September 2005. Before concluding my speech at this session, I made a statement, which I regard as one of the most important in my political life. I said: "I deem it a proud privilege that while the first session was presided over by Shri Atalji, the party's silver jubilee session being held this December at Mumbai is going to be presided over by me. I had accepted this responsibility as party president in October 2004 because Shri Venkaiahji had some personal problems. I have decided, however, that after the Mumbai session, I shall demit office, and the party's stewardship should be taken over by some other colleague."

The BJP held a special session of the national council in Mumbai on 28-30 December 2005 to mark the conclusion of the silver jubilee year. It was the last such session that I presided over. I had no regrets and no disappointments. I had the satisfaction of having served my party dutifully and conscientiously and the determination to continue to do so in the future. In Mumbai, I passed on the baton to Rajnath Singh.